Within a few decades, the Portuguese used their cannons to establish a string of outposts in the Indian Ocean. Control over Socotra and Muscat allowed them to control the Red Sea and Persian Gulf respectively. In 1510, they conquered Goa. A year later, a fleet sent out from Goa took over Melaka and established control over the key shipping route to the Spice Islands. Soon, they had trading posts in Macau and Nagasaki. The Portuguese maintained control over the seas with an iron fist and, even by the standards of the time, gained a reputation for extreme cruelty and religious bigotry. They destroyed numerous Hindu temples, persecuted the Syrian Christians and harassed ships carrying Muslims for the Hajj, on occasion burning the ships mid-sea with the pilgrims still on board. Perhaps no one suffered more from Portuguese repression than the Sri Lankans, both Tamils and Sinhalese. Much of the island was in a state of almost constant war for one and a half centuries. One can only be grateful that the Portuguese lacked the resources to attempt a full-scale conquest of the subcontinent.

Portuguese control over the Indian Ocean was based on a network of forts along the coast. The best preserved of these forts is in Diu, a small island just off the Gujarat coast. I recommend climbing the ramparts to see the beautiful views of the Arabian Sea and the impressive array of sixteenth- and seventeenth-century cannons. There are few places in the world where one can see and touch such a large number of early cannons, their solid wood wheels weathered by centuries of rain and sun. In 1538, the Portuguese were able to defend Diu against a combined attack by the Sultan of Gujarat and a large fleet sent by the Ottoman Turks. A huge Ottoman cannon, cast in 1531 in Egypt, is the only remnant of the failed Turkish expedition and can still be seen in Junagarh fort. The Portuguese would manage to hold on to Diu till as recently as 1961. The last of the outposts in Asia, Macau, was handed back to the Chinese in 1999. The Portuguese had been the first Europeans to come to this part of the world and they were the last to leave.